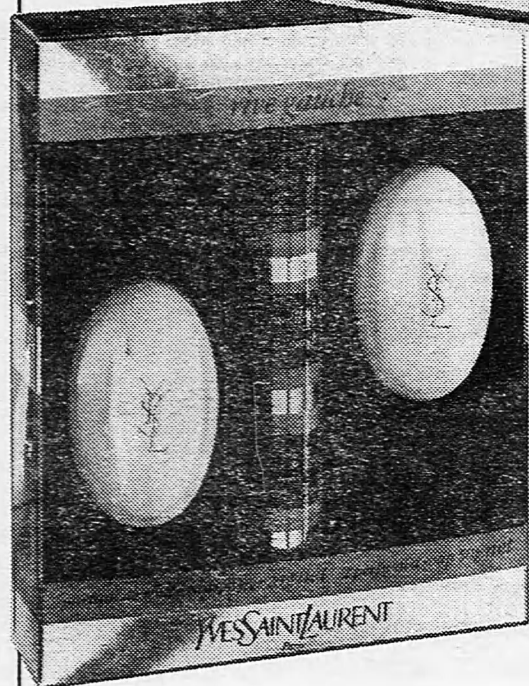


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tempo

The trials of a non-vegetarian ...



"HAVE YOU NOTICED ANYTHING DIFFERENT ABOUT JACK LATELY?."

THERE is no question; the vegetarians are closing in.

Our friends Rod and Roma have gone all the way. It is darned tricky having them to dinner. We have tried Broccoli Pie, Spinach Quiche, and even ventured into Cauliflower Delight.

Reg and Annette are only half vegetarian. They are subscribers to Time and Readers Digest. They are deep into the very latest high cholesterol panic, and they believe low fats are the true path to eternal life. So when we have them to dinner we can get away with chicken or fish.

We had an American student staying with us. She started to do too much reading and went utterly vegan. I mean she wouldn't even look at an egg. We had to go for soybean croquettes and barley-stuffed cabbage rolls.

We even have a daughter who shudders at the sight of red meat. You are nearer to God when you are close to spinach salad than a lamb chop.

So that's the trouble, you see. It's not that we dislike the taste of meat, it's that increasingly we are being surrounded by guilts and terrors.

Lettuce has lived an extraordinarily charmed life. Everything, even milk, has been on the "it will kill you list" but, strangely, lettuce has escaped.

We try to discuss the argument: Is it right to kill living creatures for our dinner table? Well, you think of all those wonderful herds of Aberdeen Angus, the Herefords, the incredible Santa Gertrudis ... but for carnivores they wouldn't exist.



Nobody has ever put the question to the animals: "All right Aberdeen Angus, it's unfortunate, at the end of the line you are going to get eaten. But how will you have it, be eaten or never exist in the first place?"

But then there was that Indian scientist Sir Jagadis Chandra Bose, who had conversations with plants. He wrote a dramatic report of the agony suffered by a cabbage when it was boiled to death on the kitchen stove. He told how a green pea, when it dies at boiling point, tries to revenge itself on the cook by emitting an electric current.

There are those who are convinced that plants, vegetables and all living things respond better to music.

Anyhow we haven't had any choice, the vegetarians have triumphed at our place and this year we decided with immense seriousness to take up the growing of vegetables.

Besides, I was impressed by the argument in the gardening column that what with the high prices at the market, if we grew our own we could save \$20 to \$30 a week.

We had a marvellous plot in a bush setting. I bought spade, maddock, hoe, axe ... \$60. Our neighbour said: "Lot of rabbits round here. No way known your lettuce'll survive unless you put a fence around your plot."

Bought wire, bought posts wire cutters, staples ... \$75.

Built that fence and my neighbour said: "Pretty dead-lookin' soil. It's gonna need a lotta feedin'."

By KEITH DUNSTAN

Actually I thought we were the people that were going to be fed. I bought blood and bone, bags of pulverised manure, lime, liquid manure ... \$40. Then I heard on the ABC garden session that seaweed was the answer. Vegetable gardens cried out for seaweed. Well, we drove all the way to the bayside, and you wouldn't believe the number of people down there with plastic bags filling up with seaweed.

It makes you wonder why councils spend so much money cleaning beaches all through the summer. Just spread the word a bit more that seaweed and empty cans are good for the garden, and they'll be cleaned in a minute.

Then *Our Garden* magazine said it was essential to have a compost bin. Fill it with vegetable waste from the kitchen, garden clippings, ash, seaweed. Cost of compost bin, cost of seaweed safaris ... \$130.

We went to the nursery and bought everything in sight, spinach, beans, peas, carrots, zucchini, lettuce, rhubarb, cauliflower, tomatoes, corn ... \$30.

Pretty smartly, bugs began to eat everything — you wouldn't believe the variety of bugs available. So we bought a spray, bug killer, Derris dust, snail bait ... more seedlings to replace those already eaten ... \$30.

Good grief, have you ever noticed how much water is required by vegetables? We couldn't be on site all the time to water our vegetables. I had to buy a special hose. Then I saw a thing that was activated by the dawn light, go for 20 minutes at dawn, go on for another 20 minutes at sunset, \$90.

At last everything began to grow. We spent hours personally feeding the lettuce. Even the children at six months didn't get the personal feeding treatment received by those lettuce.

When we came to eat them they were half the size of the lettuce down at the corner vegetable shop. The cauliflowers were slightly grey and maybe a third bought size. I said: "Why aren't my vegetables as big as bought vegetables?"

She said very sweetly: "That's not the point, dear. Your vegetables are utterly fresh straight out of the garden and they taste so much sweeter. What's more, they are organically grown."

I contented myself with that thought when we ate the pencil sized, cancer-preventing, student corn. However the squash were quite noble, and the tomatoes — you should have seen our tomatoes — they had such robust beauty I didn't want to eat them.

However at the season's end reluctantly I did a little cost accounting. I reckon those tomatoes cost around a dollar each. Make it a \$1.50 for the squash and I'm not even going to tell you what the cauliflowers were worth.

But the dreadful truth is that Hilton and Olivia, avowed carnivores, gave me a barbecue for my birthday. We had a secret tryst with chops and sausages on Sunday.

That sort of thing could catch on.